

# THE WRATH OF ARCHIE ELLIS



*m kirk*

AFTER THE NOVEL

*I saw a man this morning*

I saw a man this morning  
Who did not wish to die:  
I ask, and cannot answer,  
If otherwise wish I.

Fair broke the day this morning  
Against the Dardanelles;  
The breeze blew soft, the morn's cheeks  
Were cold as cold sea-shells.

But other shells are waiting  
Across the Aegean sea,  
Shrapnel and high explosive,  
Shells and hells for me.

O hell of ships and cities,  
Hell of men like me,  
Fatal second Helen,  
Why must I follow thee?

Achilles came to Troyland  
And I to Chersonese:  
He turned from wrath to battle,  
And I from three days' peace.

Was it so hard, Achilles,  
So very hard to die?  
Thou knewest and I know not –  
So much the happier I.

I will go back this morning  
From Imbros over the sea;  
Stand in the trench, Achilles,  
Flame-capped, and shout for me.

Patrick Shaw-Stewart  
*Imbros, 1915*

## The grammar of collapse

Edward VII was buried on the twentieth of May 1910. Nine reigning monarchs followed the coffin and seventy nations were represented. It was a hundred and twelve years before that many crowns were in one place again, at the funeral of Elizabeth II.

Barbara Tuchman opens *The Guns of August* with that morning. I read it at twelve and I have been circling this war ever since. I could not have named one of those kings. The morning read like the end of something. It was the first chapter. Everyone reading this knows that. Nobody in the procession did.

They were relations. The Kings of Denmark and Greece were the dead king's brothers-in-law. The King of Norway was his son-in-law. The German Emperor was his nephew and the new British king's first cousin, the two of them grandsons of Victoria, who had been dead nine years and was still arranging the seating.

In May it looked permanent. The King of Portugal was off his throne that October. Of the nine who followed the coffin, four still had a throne at the end of 1918. Three had lost theirs and two were dead.

Not everyone in the procession was a king. Austria-Hungary sent its heir, and four years later he was shot at Sarajevo. Russia sent the Tsar's brother, who was offered the crown in March 1917, declined it the next morning, and was shot in a forest outside Perm fifteen months later, the first of his family the Bolsheviks killed. China sent a prince whose dynasty had less than two years to run.

And within four years the King of the Belgians would be holding the last unoccupied corner of his own country, and he would hold it for four more. About two hundred square miles braced into the northwest with the sea at his back. The ground this novel takes place on is the southern end of it.

Underneath the funeral was a machine. By some measures Europe in 1913 was more economically integrated than it would be again for sixty years. Foreign assets stood at close to a fifth of world output. Britain

imported four fifths of its wheat. The gold standard tied the currencies together and undersea cables ran from London to every continent. German and British engineers attended the same conferences and read the same journals. In 1910 a British writer named Norman Angell argued in *The Great Illusion* that war between such closely bound powers had become economically irrational. He was right about the economics.

The shape of what happened next is not the cause of it. Droughts and railway timetables have nothing to say to each other. The shape is that the connections which carry a world to its height are the connections a failure travels along, so that the reach of the network sets the reach of the collapse. It had happened before. Gibbon wrote about Rome, and Rome is the picture nearly everyone carries of how a civilization ends: a long decline, and an argument about the date that is still running. It is the wrong picture. The one that matches is older than Rome, and nobody wrote it down. The record of it is not a book.

In the 1980s, divers off the southern coast of Turkey began raising the cargo of a merchant ship that went down around 1300 BCE near the headland of Uluburun. Ten tons of copper, a ton of tin, Canaanite resin, Baltic amber, African ivory, Mycenaean pottery. The metals have been traced to their sources: copper from Cyprus, tin partly from Anatolia and partly from a mining district in what is now Uzbekistan. The origins of one cargo span five thousand kilometers.

One ship.

The great kings of Egypt, Babylon, the Hittites and Mitanni wrote to one another in Akkadian, a diplomatic language none of them spoke, and addressed one another as brother. Copper came from one end of the known world and tin from beyond the other, and without both there was no bronze. Within a century of that voyage every major palace economy in the eastern Mediterranean had collapsed or shrunk to a village. Ugarit was destroyed and never rebuilt. The Hittite court appears to have emptied its own capital before the city burned. Every failure traveled along the same connections that had made the whole thing work. The victors went down with the vanquished: the Greeks who sacked Troy went home, and within a generation or two their own palaces burned.

The archaeology gives half of that. It gives the cascade: the drought, the harvests, the routes, the burned floors. What it cannot give is the code, and

the code is a smaller and more exact thing than it sounds. It is a handful of words. *Timē*, what a man is held to be worth by the people who watched him earn it. *Kleos*, what is said about him afterwards, and for how long. There are four or five of them, they are glossed at the back of this book, and they are what turns a cascade into a sequence of decisions men make on purpose.

For the code there is one source, and he is a poet, and he was not there.

He did not write it either. Writing went down with the palaces and stayed gone for four hundred years, so the poem crossed those centuries in people's mouths. The collapse had taken the other way of carrying things.

Homer sang about the men who lived at the edge of that collapse, four or five centuries after it, and his audience knew what Achilles and Hector did not: that Troy would fall, and that the world which made its conquerors was ending too. Both armies are standing at the top of their world. Achilles is arguing about a prize, and nothing in that poem is running out. The men behind the coffin did not look up either.

Three thousand years later, Europe took that poem and put it in the hands of every boy it intended to make an officer of.

The English public schools taught Greek and Latin as moral instruction rather than as literature, and boys at Eton and Harrow construed the *Iliad* for years. Construing was the classroom drill of the day: stand, translate a line aloud word by word, and account for the grammar of each one. Greek was in the entrance examination at both Oxford and Cambridge, and a boy who could not construe it could not matriculate. Germany ran the same system from the same source and had thought harder about why. From Winckelmann through Humboldt, German Hellenism placed Greece at the center of what a cultivated man was for; Humboldt built the Prussian schools around it, nine years of it, ages ten to eighteen; Johann Heinrich Voss's translations had made Homer a German book, and Goethe read him in Greek. Neither country was educating a nation. The Gymnasium reached perhaps three per cent of the population, and that three per cent is where the army got its officers. A boy did not read Homer because he cared for poetry. He read it because that was what being educated consisted of, and what he took out of it was not a story but a set of settled answers: what a brave man is, what an insult costs, what is owed to the dead, what a name is worth and how long it lasts.

Both systems produced the same type: a man given an ancient code and asked to live inside it in an increasingly modern world.

The English version is the man whose poem opens this section. Patrick Shaw-Stewart went from Eton to Balliol and took a double first, in Classical Moderations in 1908 and in Greats in 1910. All Souls elected him to a fellowship and he declined it. He went into Barings instead, and by 1913 he was one of the youngest managing directors in the bank's history. Then the machine failed, and it was the training that answered. He wrote the poem on Imbros in the summer of 1915, and he was killed on the thirtieth of December 1917, commanding the Hood Battalion, six weeks after the last page of this book.

The German version went through both systems. Ernst Stadler came out of the Protestant Gymnasium at Strasbourg, took two doctorates, and went to Magdalen College, Oxford, on a Rhodes scholarship, where he spent two years among Englishmen of his own age and training. He was a philologist and a poet. In 1913 he published *Der Aufbruch*, and the University of Toronto offered him a post, which he accepted and was to take up at the end of September 1914. He reported to his reserve corps instead, and was killed by a shell at a quarter past seven in the morning on the thirtieth of October 1914, at Zandvoorde, south-east of Ypres. Inside the Salient. Three years before this novel opens. Magdalen left him off its war memorial, and in 1994 the college put up a second plaque beside the first one and put his name on that.

One man saw it coming. On the third of August 1914 the British Foreign Secretary said that the lamps were going out all over Europe and that they would not be lit again in his lifetime. It is the most quoted sentence about that war. Nobody wrote it down at the time. Edward Grey published it himself in 1925, by which point the war he was predicting had come and gone, and the man who heard him confirmed it in 1927. The prophecy is a memory, written down by a man who already knew he had been right. Even the exception is a document made afterwards, and the news always arrives later, from somebody who was not there.

Grey was not pessimistic enough. What followed was a false dawn in the middle of the twenties, then a depression, then men who promised order, then a second war that killed more people than any event in human history, and then a wire across the continent for forty years. Germany was one country again in 1990, eighty years after the funeral. Rome came apart

over centuries and historians still argue about when it finished. This took five weeks.

The kings of the Bronze Age called one another brother in a language none of them spoke. The kings who rode behind Edward VII's coffin did not have to pretend, because they were cousins. Neither arrangement was any protection at all. Four empires went into the war that followed that funeral and none of them came out: the German, the Austro-Hungarian, the Ottoman and the Russian. Three were on the losing side. The fourth had been an ally of the winners for three years, and it made no difference. The victors went down with the vanquished again. Ugarit was never rebuilt either.

The wire did not run between two traditions. It ran through one. Both times the men inside it had been handed the same instrument for understanding what was happening to them, three thousand years old, with no word in it for a bombardment that goes on for a fortnight.

The strength was the fragility.

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**Further reading.** Christopher Clark, *The Sleepwalkers* (2012), on the five weeks between Sarajevo and the outbreak, and on the eleven years of decisions behind them. The title is this essay's argument in one word. Eric H. Cline, *1177 B.C.: The Year Civilization Collapsed* (2014), for the Bronze Age and the Uluburun cargo. Both of them conclude that no single cause did it, which is the caution this essay tries to keep. Barbara Tuchman, *The Guns of August* (1962), for the funeral at the top of this section, which is where I got it. Christopher Stray, *Classics Transformed* (1998), which is a scholar's book and the only full account of how Greek became an English institution and then stopped being one. And Elizabeth Vandiver, *Stand in the Trench, Achilles: Classical Receptions in British Poetry of the Great War* (2010), which takes its title from the last line of the poem at the front of this section, and which is the book I would have had to write first if she had not written it already.